

Qing Dynasty, the rebels employed women in farming and construction. Women's work even extended to politics and education. Females were permitted to sit examinations and scrutinize Confucian texts for the first time.

However, although new opportunities materialized, the gap between reality and rhetoric was greater than first appeared. While the rebellion promised equality and liberation, newly independent women were often considered promiscuous and unprincipled. Furthermore, women's work groups were separate from men's, and those women who achieved any political authority were unable to exert influence over men, suggesting that segregation had simply been dressed up as egalitarianism. Chastity remained a focus in Taiping principalities, and some Qing traditionalism was deeply ingrained, meaning that the promise of real gender equality was never fulfilled.



▲ The ruling elite

This 19th-century lithograph depicts upper-class Manchu women of the Qing Dynasty. After capturing Nanjing, the Taiping rebels killed all Manchu men, and then burned the Manchu women to death.

▼ Taking Anqing

Qing soldiers laid siege to the Taiping city of Anqing for a year. When it fell, the Qing killed the Taiping men and took more than 10,000 women for their own pleasure.

